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“We have to reverse the perception that Bengal is anti-business”

West Bengal Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta, on restoring investor confidence and steering the state towards a business-first approach

BY SIDDHARTH ZARABI

FOR DECADES, SWAPAN DASGUPTA made his name as a journalist, columnist, and conservative intellectual interpreting politics from the outside. Now, as West Bengal’s finance minister in the state’s first BJP government, he

has been handed a rather different brief—helping turn around an economy he describes as having endured 50 years of uninterrupted decline.

The BJP’s emphatic mandate, Dasgupta argues, reflected not only anger at misgovernance

but an impatience with Bengal’s prolonged economic stagnation, the flight of talent, and a reputation for hostility to business. His task, as he sees it, is as much psychological as fiscal—restore confidence, persuade entrepreneurs that

Bengal has changed, and give young people reasons to build their futures at home.

Dasgupta is not promising miracles. Land remains scarce and politically fraught; state finances are strained; welfare expectations are deeply

PHOTOS BY ARUN KUMAR